EXCERPT | PARENT ROUNDTABLE SERIES

Histamine, Sleep, and the Nervous System

What histamine does, why it can keep a child awake, and what families can do about it

Deborah M. Burke-Allen, RPh
Registered Pharmacist | Parent education roundtable



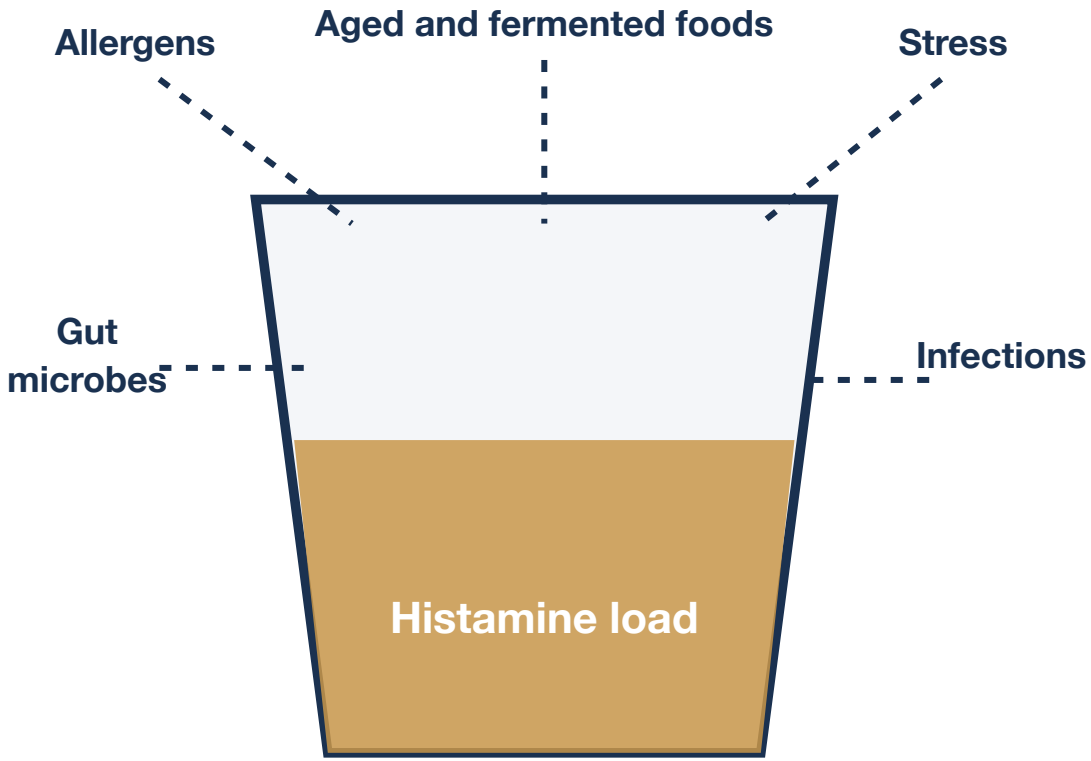
In the brain, histamine is a wake-up signal

- A small cluster of histamine neurons in the hypothalamus fires during waking and goes quiet during sleep
- Older antihistamines that cross into the brain block this signal, which is why they cause drowsiness
- When histamine runs high, a child can feel **wired and tired**: exhausted, but unable to settle



Haas H, Panula P. Nat Rev Neurosci. 2003;4(2):121-30. PMID 12563283

Many sources fill the bucket; symptoms appear when it overflows



- Food, allergens, stress hormones, infections, and some gut microbes all add histamine
- DAO and HNMT drain the bucket
- A child may tolerate a food one week and react the next because the total load changed, not the food

Maintz L, Novak N. Am J Clin Nutr. 2007;85(5):1185-96. PMID 17490952

WHAT PARENTS CAN DO

Lower the load, support clearance, and protect sleep

Lower the load

- Track symptoms with meals, stress, and season
- Favor fresh foods over leftovers and aged foods during flares
- Reduce dust and mold at home

Support clearance

- Build meals around nutrient-dense whole foods
- Ask a clinician before adding supplements
- Bring a full medicine list to every visit

Protect sleep

- Keep a steady bedtime routine
- Keep the room cool, dark, and quiet
- Treat itch and congestion so they do not wake your child

> Talk with your pediatrician or pharmacist before using any antihistamine to help a child sleep.

WANT THE FULL DECK?

This is an excerpt from a full parent-education roundtable

- Designed, researched, and presented by a registered pharmacist
- Every clinical claim cited and verified in PubMed
- Written for parents; reviewed to a professional medical-content standard

See the full deck and more

deborahburkeallen.github.io/recruiters.html

bridgestowellness@icloud.com